

COAST-TO-COAST

This Fokker T-2, powered by a 420hp Liberty engine, was originally designed as a transport plane for the US Army Air Service. Modified with extra fuel tanks built into the wings, it made the first nonstop flight across the US in May 1923, piloted by Lieutenants John Macready and Oakley Kelly.

The DLH pilots had to traverse the great empty spaces of Soviet Asia beyond the Urals with no accurate maps, no weather reports, no spare parts to be had, and often only primitive airfields. They then entered China, a dangerous and unstable country fought over by rival warlords whose attitude to the arrival of foreign aircraft was difficult to predict. After many difficulties, they not only made it to Peking but also flew back again to Germany.

Global imposition

The image of the aviator as a high-tech hero astonishing “primitive” imperial subjects was one of the most satisfactory aspects of aviation for the European public. The book jacket of British aviator Alan Cobham’s account of a flight from Britain to Cape Town, South Africa, and back, published in 1926, shows natives with spears and shields looking up in awe at his de Havilland D.H.50 passing overhead. But unfriendly locals could be a hazard for trail-blazing pilots in untamed areas of the globe. In the 1920s the French were fighting a Berber uprising in Morocco, while Britain tackled an Arab rebellion in Iraq. Since military aircraft were being used by the French and British against these rebels, their attitude to any aviators who crossed their territory was, not surprisingly, hostile.

During Cobham’s flight to Australia and back, his mechanic, Arthur Elliott, was shot dead by a bullet fired at the aircraft from the ground near Basra in southern Iraq. French airmail pilots pioneering the route down the desert coast of North Africa from Casablanca to Dakar frequently

“We have just witnessed a page of history being turned; a dream has come true.”

CALIFORNIA NEWSPAPER ON MACREADY AND KELLY’S FIRST NONSTOP US CROSSING

drew fire from camel-riding nomads. When a future hero of French aviation, pilot Jean Mermoz, came down in the desert in 1926, he was taken prisoner by tribesmen and held in a cave until a ransom was paid for his release. Later in the same year three of his colleagues were less fortunate after another forced landing – two were shot dead and the other, although ransomed, died later as a result of mistreatment in captivity.

BRITISH HERO

Celebrated British aviator Alan Cobham is shown landing his modified de Havilland D.H.50f biplane alongside the Houses of Parliament on October 1, 1926. Crowds lined the Thames River in London to applaud Cobham’s completion of his three-month, 26,703-mile (43,992-km) England–Australia round-trip.



RECORD-BREAKERS

Lieutenants John Macready (left) and Oakley Kelly stand beside the tanks of fuel that powered their nonstop flight across America. They covered the 2,650 miles (4,240km) from Long Island, New York, to San Diego, California, in just under 27 hours.

